



From IFSP to IEP

The Age 3 Transition Guide — What Every Caregiver Needs to Know

Knowledge is power. Partnership is progress. Together — the IEP gets APPROVED.

The Most Missed Moment in Special Education

When your child turns 3, one of the most significant transitions in special education happens — and most families are caught off guard. Part C Early Intervention services end. Part B preschool special education begins. The IFSP becomes an IEP. And everything changes.

This guide gives you exactly what you need to navigate this transition confidently — and what to do if things go wrong.

What Changes at Age 3

	Before Age 3 (Part C)	Age 3 and After (Part B)
Document	IFSP	IEP
Focus	Family-centered	Child/educational focus
Setting	Natural environment (home, daycare)	Least restrictive environment (school)
Lead agency	State Early Intervention agency	Local school district (LEA)
Service coordinator	Assigned to you	Case manager (may change)
Head Start overlap	Common	Less common — school-based services

The Transition Timeline

At age 2 years 6 months (90 days before 3rd birthday)

Your IFSP must include a transition plan. The Early Intervention program must notify the school district of your child's upcoming transition. A transition conference must be held — you must be invited.

Before the 3rd birthday

The school district must evaluate your child to determine eligibility for preschool special education under Part B. You must consent to this evaluation.

By the 3rd birthday



If eligible, an IEP must be in place and services must be ready to begin on your child's third birthday. There cannot be a gap in services.

After the 3rd birthday

IEP services begin. Part C services end. The school district is now responsible.

What If My Child Doesn't Qualify for Part B?

Some children who received Early Intervention services under Part C may not qualify for a preschool IEP under Part B — the eligibility criteria are different. If your child is found ineligible, you have the right to:

- Receive a written explanation of why your child was found ineligible
- Request an Independent Educational Evaluation if you disagree
- Ask about a 504 Plan, which has a broader eligibility standard
- Ask about Head Start services if your child is income-eligible
- Re-request an evaluation at any time if your child's needs change

Head Start at Age 3-5

Head Start serves children ages 3-5 (Early Head Start serves birth-3). If your child has an IEP, they can still attend Head Start — and the school district must provide IEP services in that setting if it is the appropriate placement.

- Head Start is required to reserve 10% of enrollment for children with disabilities
- IEP services can be delivered within the Head Start program
- Head Start and the school district must coordinate — they should be talking to each other
- Head Start Disabilities Services Coordinator is your key contact
- Head Start can be an appropriate LRE for preschool children with disabilities

Your Transition Checklist

- ☐ Attended the transition conference (required at 2.5 years)
- ☐ Received written notice of the transition plan in the IFSP
- ☐ Consented to Part B evaluation by the school district
- ☐ Attended the eligibility determination meeting
- ☐ Attended the IEP meeting before my child's 3rd birthday
- ☐ Confirmed IEP services start ON the 3rd birthday — no gap
- ☐ Received a copy of the IEP and Procedural Safeguards
- ☐ Know who my child's case manager is at the school district
- ☐ Know which school or program my child will attend



[] If Head Start: confirmed the school district will deliver services there

My questions for the transition conference:

Concerns about the transition I want to raise:

Remember: No Gap in Services Is Allowed

If your child qualifies for Part B services, those services must begin on their third birthday. The law does not allow a waiting period. If the school district tells you services will start "after the school year begins" or "in a few weeks," that is a violation of IDEA. Put your concerns in writing immediately and contact your state's Parent Training and Information Center.